Praise of the Unsurpassed

Niruttarastava · Toh 1130 · Derge Tengyur
བར་ཟློ་མདེ་པའ་བིསརྟོ་ས

Praise of the Unsurpassed, known in Sanskrit as the Niruttarastava and in Tibetan as Lana Mepé Töpa, is a brief hymn of eight verses ascribed in its colophon to the master Nāgārjuna. Each verse ends with the refrain "Homage to that Unsurpassed One," and together they praise the Buddha as one who has left behind both this shore and the far shore, for whom there is neither knowing nor not knowing, neither meditation nor non-meditation, whose single luminous wisdom discerns everything knowable, and who has abandoned existence and nonexistence alike. Its compact and at times enigmatic images, such as particles that are as unreal as a snake's legs and a dancer whose steps are guided by miraculous power, join devotion to the Middle Way teaching that nothing has intrinsic nature. It is Toh 1130 in the Tengyur, where it belongs to the section of praises (stotra).

In the language of India: niruttastavaṃ. In the language of Tibet: Praise of the Unsurpassed.

Homage to the youthful Mañjuśrī.

You who have abandoned this shore and the far shore,
Who by the miraculous power of wisdom have cleared
The supreme own nature of all that can be known:
To that Unsurpassed One I pay homage and offer praise.

For whom there is neither knowing nor not knowing,
Neither yogin nor ordinary person,
For whom there is neither meditation nor non-meditation:
Homage to that Unsurpassed One!

You whose single wisdom is luminous,
Fully discerning all that can be known without exception,
Thus equal and immeasurable:
Homage to that Unsurpassed One!

For whom the particles, coarse and subtle,
Heavy and light,
Like the legs of a snake, have no intrinsic nature:
Homage to that Unsurpassed One!

You by whom, as when someone goes upon a plain
By the strength of an insect,
The darkness is dispelled by light:
Homage to that Unsurpassed One!

You who, with miraculous power full of emanations,
Like a dancer moving his feet,
See the path and know the path:
Homage to that Unsurpassed One!

You for whom there are neither parts
Nor emptiness of objects, who have abandoned both,
All-knowing one, foremost lord:
Homage to that Unsurpassed One!

You who have utterly abandoned all faults,
Who are far removed from the nature of stains,
Who have abandoned existence and nonexistence:
Homage to that Unsurpassed One!

The Praise of the Unsurpassed, composed by the revered great master, the noble Nāgārjuna, is complete.

Translator's Notes

• The fifth stanza is obscure. The "insect" (□□□□□□□) may be a glow-worm, whose faint light lets a traveler cross a plain at night, set beside the Buddha's light that dispels darkness; I have kept the image literal. The seventh stanza is also compressed: I take □□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□ as "neither parts nor emptiness of objects," that is, the two extremes of real composite things and of utter absence, both of which the Buddha has abandoned.

Colophon

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Just as the Bodhi tree now standing at Bodh Gayā neither is nor is not the same tree beneath which the Buddha attained awakening, so too this stupa is intended as the next generation of stupa — dependently arising according to the conditions of its environment, and ceaselessly

proclaiming the Dharma for the benefit of all sentient beings.

May whoever encounters these words derive great benefit.